

CHITTARANJAN LOCOMOTIVE WORKS

The setting up of the Chittaranjan Locomotive Works (CLW) marked India's first step towards becoming self-sufficient in locomotive production. Originally called the Loco Building Factory, it was renamed as a tribute to the freedom fighter, Deshbandhu (friend of the nation) Chittaranjan Das.

Production began on 26 January 1950 and five types of steam locomotives were built until 1973–74. The factory began manufacturing diesel hydraulic locomotives from 1968, building 842 vehicles of seven types until 1993–94. Some important electric engines produced by the CLW included *Lokmany*a (WCM5), commissioned by India's first prime minister, Jawaharlal Nehru, in 1961, *Bidhan* (WAG-1), the factory's first indigenous locomotive, *Navyug* (WAG-9), one of the most powerful freight engines built in 1998, and *Navikaran* (WAP-7), the three-phase AC electric passenger locomotive, which was released in 2000. Government figures indicate that the workshop produced 6,791 electric locomotives between 1961 and 2019.

Several additions were made to the CLW, starting from 1955, with the installation of a plant for galvanizing steel masts. By 1969, almost 50,000 tonnes of steel masts had been galvanized and used on electrification projects. A steel foundry was established in 1961 to make the production of steel castings more self-sufficient and manufactured intricate steel castings weighing up to four tonnes. Prior to this, steel castings were imported from the US. An electric locomotive shop (1962) and traction motor shop (1966) also came up.

The industrial town of Chittaranjan in West Bengal, which stood on 1,800 hectares of land, was built to accommodate life that would grow around this manufacturing unit. The township is divided into colonies with playgrounds, dispensaries, children's parks, schools, social